

Day 2 — The Sāṅkhya Tattva Ladder

Module: Pañcabhūta (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students draw and label all 25 tattvas in the Sāṅkhya scheme, and locate the five bhūtas within the full enumeration.

Materials

- Large whiteboard or pinboard
- A4 sheets for students
- Sources excerpt: Larson's *Classical Sāṅkhya* summary (teacher-prepared, 1 page)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- 2 students share their homework question from Day 1.
- Quick recap: "Five elements emerge LAST in Sāṅkhya. Today we see what comes first."

Core (25 min)

1. Build the ladder on the board, slowly:

25. puruṣa (consciousness, the witness)
24. prakṛti (primordial nature, unmanifest)
_____ (evolution begins)
23. buddhi / mahat (intellect)
22. ahaṅkāra (ego, sense of "I")
_____ (branch into three lines)

Mental:	Sense organs:	Action organs:
21. manas (mind) (speech)	20. śrotra (ear)	15. vāk
(hand)	19. tvac (skin)	14. pāṇi
(foot)	18. cakṣus (eye)	13. pāda
(anus)	17. rasanā (tongue)	12. pāyu
(genitals)	16. ghrāṇa (nose)	11. upastha

_____ (subtle elements, 10–6):
10. śabda-tanmātra (sound)
9. sparśa-tanmātra (touch)
8. rūpa-tanmātra (form)

7. rasa-tanmātra (taste)
6. gandha-tanmātra (smell)

Mahābhūtas (gross elements, 5–1):

5. ākāśa (space)
4. vāyu (air)
3. tejas (fire)
2. ap (water)
1. pṛthvī (earth)

(Numbering convention varies in different Sāṅkhya texts; here we count from the most concrete (1 = earth) up to the most abstract (24 = prakṛti) with puruṣa as the silent 25th. Other texts count from puruṣa down.)

2. The key structural insight:

- The five gross elements (*mahābhūtas*) are the LAST and most concrete layer.
- Each is paired with a *tanmātra* (subtle quality, the perceptual essence).
- Each tanmātra is what the corresponding sense-organ perceives.
- The whole scheme is internally consistent: the bhūtas, tanmātras, and indriyas line up in a tight one-to-one mapping.

Diagram exercise (10 min)

Students draw the 25-tattva ladder in their notebooks. Use colour to mark the five bhūtas distinctly.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Quick check: “Where do the five elements sit in the ladder?” (At the bottom — the most concrete, most manifest layer.)
- Preview Day 3: “Tomorrow — the *bhūta-tanmātra* pairing in detail, and why the quality-count rule follows.”

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read the full first 22 verses of the Sāṅkhya Kārikā in translation. Note one verse you find puzzling.
- **Tier down:** Focus on the bhūtas + tanmātras layer. The full ladder can be a reference.

Teacher notes

- The 25-tattva count is the *classical Sāṅkhya* count (Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s *Sāṅkhya Kārikā*, c. 4th c. CE). Different versions of Sāṅkhya count differently.
- Be honest about the *non-theistic* character of classical Sāṅkhya. It does NOT include a creator god as a tattva. The Yoga school (*Yoga Sūtras*) adds *Īśvara* as a separate principle; classical Sāṅkhya does not.

Citation(s) used

- SB 3.5.36 — vidya-karana RAG cache day-02-creation.json#chunks[1]

- Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya* (1979), chapters on tattva enumeration.